Parental Leave Is a Heterogeneous Package, Not a Unitary Exposure

A Norwegian maternity-leave reform is associated with better long-run child outcomes; leave remains a bundle of time, pay, eligibility, and who stays home, not a 0–3 cognitive law.

MODERATE-REFORM; LOW-TO-MODERATE-0-3; LOW-UNITARY-JOB | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: ECOLOGY, POLICY | REPLICATION: V

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Carneiro, Løken & Salvanes (2015) studied a Norwegian maternity-leave reform that extended paid leave. Children whose mothers were eligible had better long-run education and earnings outcomes than comparison cohorts. The object is a defined leave package in one institutional setting, not "employment" as a single exposure. Maternal recovery also supports psychological stabilization; severe sleep fragmentation and exhaustion during early leave absence predict postpartum rage, irritability, and depressive symptoms (Ou & Hall 2018).

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Natural-experiment / reform design, not an RCT of toddler cognition. Long-run education and earnings are not infant test scores. Adjacent: income-cash-transfer-early-development.md is a different lever (cash without mandated time). Childcare (early-childcare-quality.md) is what leave sometimes replaces. MTO is housing mobility, not leave. Sleep and attachment-intervention theory are not restated.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Long-run education and earnings effects are the identification. Near-term infant scores are not this paper's object. Persistence here is the adult outcome, not a toddler battery.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (policy natural experiment / reform evaluation, not an observational family phenotype).

Eligibility, wage replacement, duration, and which parent stays home vary across countries. A night shift and a salaried leave are not one exposure. Selection into take-up remains a threat where leave is not universal.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Employment is not a unitary harm. Leave is not a guarantee of infant cognition. A missing leave week is not a character defect, and a long leave is not a proven IQ program. Does not mean postpartum rage or maternal exhaustion reflects a personal moral failure or lack of love; these are biological indicators of physical depletion and missing structural care.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Treat leave as an institutional package. Families cannot individually legislate eligibility. A universal "stay home for cognition" script does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Carneiro, Løken & Salvanes (2015), Journal of Political Economy
- Ou & Hall (2018), Birth, DOI: 10.1111/birt.12356 (https://doi.org/10.1111/birt.12356)